

ART & CULTURE

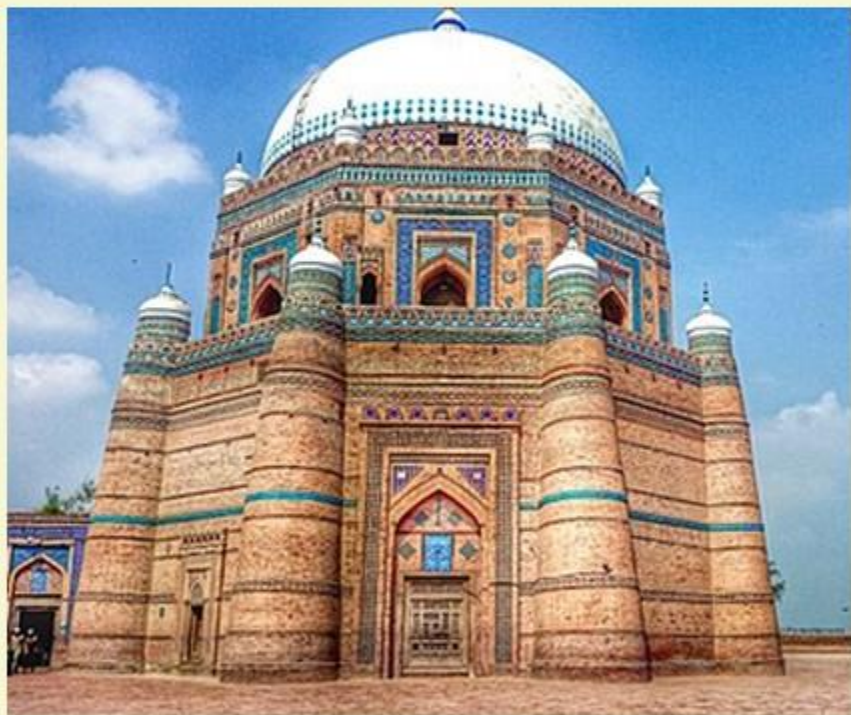


INDIAN ARCHITECTURE

MODULE - 21

**ARCHITECTURE IN
MEDIEVAL INDIA**

ARCHITECTURE IN MEDIEVAL INDIA



- 1** With the Arab conquest of Sind in 712 A.D., the arrival of the Islamic rulers to the western frontiers of India had started.
- 2** Like many other facets of Indian culture, the Indian architecture was also deeply influenced by the arrival of Islam in India.
- 3** Although the Islamic influence began in the 7th and 8th century AD through the Arab traders and later increased after the conquest of Sind, it was only in the early 13th century after the establishment of the Delhi Sultanate that the architectural and construction work started to bear the Islamic imprint on a larger scale.

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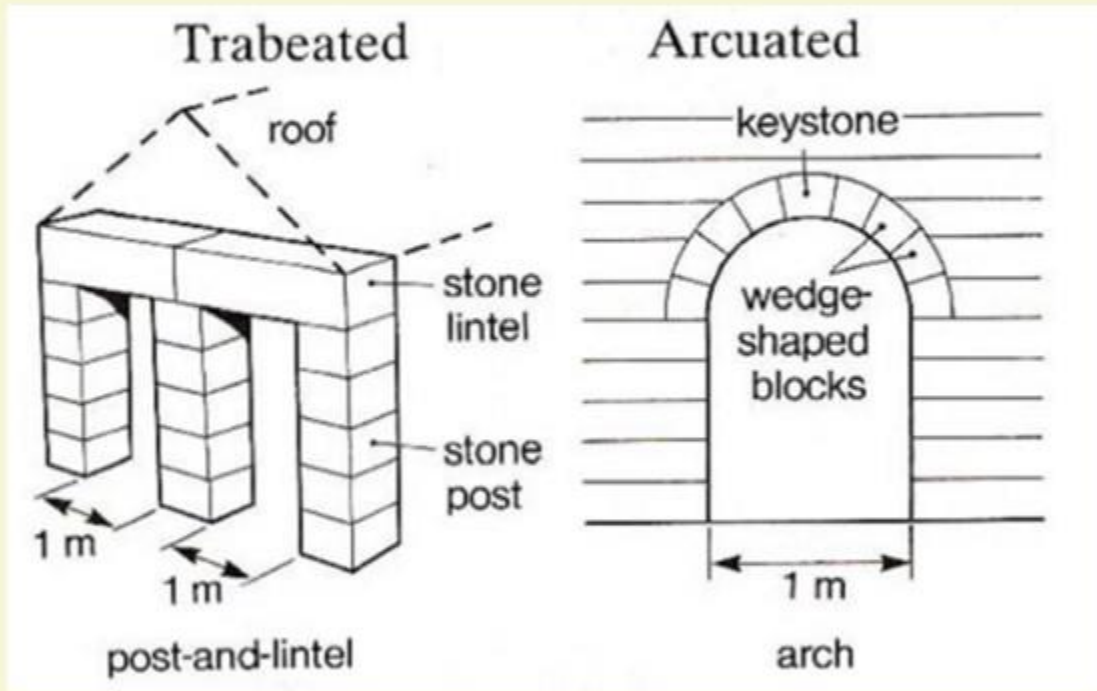


INDO-SARACENIC ARCHITECTURE

- 4 New elements, such as calligraphy, ornamentation using inlay work, etc. were introduced to reflect the tastes and preferences of the new rulers.
- 5 However, the local architects retained certain flavours of the local architectural traditions as well.
- 6 Thus, in the architecture of this following period, we see a confluence of Persian style with the Indian style.
- 7 This style which emerged came to be known as **Indo-Islamic architecture** or **Indo-Saracenic architecture**

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Some of the features of Indo-Islamic architecture are given as follows:



- 1 The use of arch and domes gained prominence during this period. It was known as 'arcuade style of architecture' and replaced the traditional Trabeat style.
- 2 The trabeat style was based on brackets, beams & pillars to support the flat roofs.
- 3 Thus, Indian architecture was previously characterised by trabeation i.e. use of beams as opposed to arches or vaulting.
- 4 The Islamic influence ushered in an era of use of arches to support large domes.

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TRABEATE ARCHITECTURE



ARCUATE ARCHITECTURE

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DIFFERENCE BETWEEN ARCUADE STYLE AND TRABEAT STYLE

BASIS	TRABEAT	ARCUADE
Entrance	Characterised by the use of Lintel.	Characterised by the use of arches and domes
Top	The use of shikhara on top of the temples. They were generally conical or curvilinear.	The use of domes on top of the mosques. Domes were generally hemispherical.
Minar	Minars were absent	Minars were present on the four corners of the mosques .
Building material	Stone was the primary component of all constructions.	Brick, lime plaster and mortar started being used for constructions.

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SHIKHARA



DOMES

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Mihrab

- 5 The walls of the mosque would have a semi-circular niche called Mihrab.
- 6 This would indicate the direction of Kabba in Mecca and the Muslims would pray facing the Mihrab which would have intricate designs and decorations
- 7 Mortar was used as a cementing agent in their constructions.

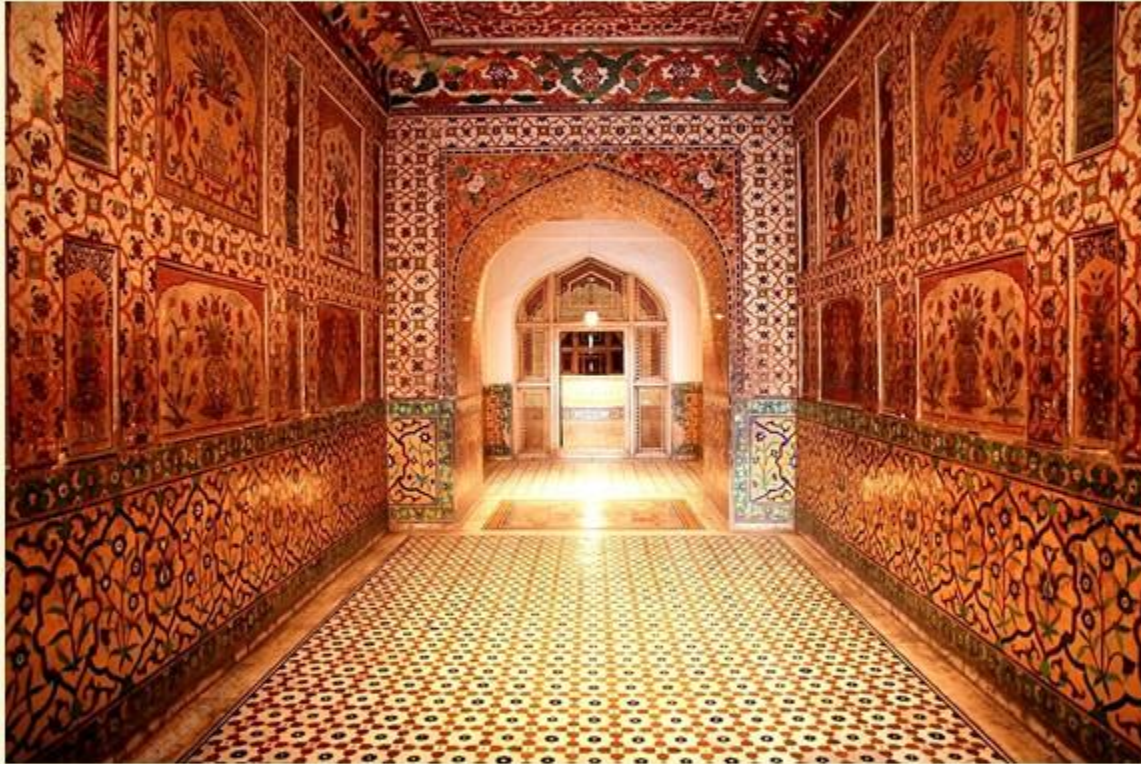
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- 8 The Islamic rulers introduced the use of minars around the mosques and the mausoleums. These were often **deployed in the periphery or corners of the mosques** and complimented the dome structure.



Qutb Minar

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A sample of Mughal Architecture inside one of the tomb of Jahangir built by Shah Jahan

- 9** While the Hindu architecture had become too congested, the Indo-Islamic architecture introduced spaciousness, massiveness and breadth to it.
- 10** The need for large spacious column free domed was a practical necessity for large congregations and community offering of prayers in Islam.

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Calligraphic Inscriptions of Islamic architecture

- 11** Islamic influence was also visible in the surface decoration. While the walls of Hindu temples had images of Gods in different forms, the Islamic structures **did not carry images of living beings**.
- 12** Thus, the Indo-Islamic architecture **avoided the use of human and animal figures**.
- 13** While the previous structures used sculptures as means of decoration, the Indo-Islamic architecture used **calligraphy** as means of decoration.

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CALLIGRAPHIC INSCRIPTIONS IN QUTB MINAR

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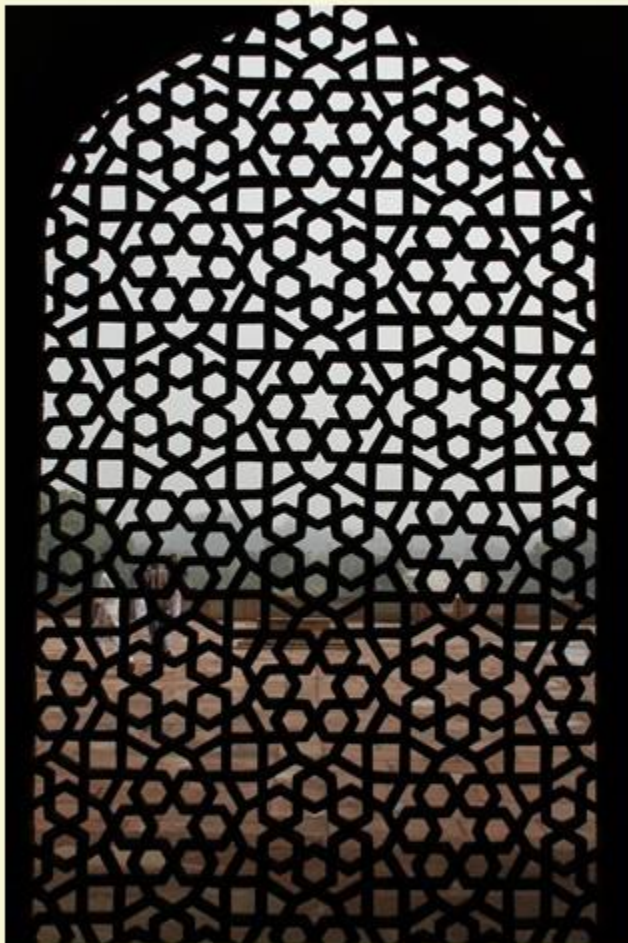
Arabesque Method

- 14** *Arabesque Method:* Arabesque method was also used for decoration. Arabesque meant the use of geometrical vegetal ornamentation and was characterised by a continuous stem which split regularly, producing a series of counterpoised, leafy, secondary stems. The secondary stems, in turn, split again or returned to merge with the main stem creating a decorative pattern.

ARABESQUE METHOD OF FLORAL PATTERN



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*Intricate Jaali work in
Humayun's tomb*

- 15** The architecture of this period heavily used the principles of geometry – from decorative pattern to imbuing a sense of symmetry.
- 16** The buildings had intricate *jaali works*, which signifies the importance of light in Islamic region.
- 17** The jaali works were perforated stones or lattice screens in the form of an ornamental pattern.

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Water as an integral part of Mughal architecture

- 18** An important feature of the architecture during this period was the **use of water** in the premises of the constructions in the form of courtyard pools, fountains and small drains. Water was used primarily for three purposes:
- Religious purpose
 - Cooling the premises
 - Decorative purpose

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- 19 The Islamic rulers introduced the *Charbagh style of gardening*, in which a square block was divided into four adjacent identical gardens.



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Pietra-dura Technique



20 The architectures of these times also used the **pietra-dura technique** for the inlay of precious stones and gems into the stone walls.

21 Another unique feature was the use of **foresightening technique** in the buildings, such that the inscriptions appear of the same size from any place.

ARCHITECTURE DURING DELHI SULTANATE PERIOD



*Quwwat-ul-Islam built by Qutb-ud-din
Aibak, founder of the Slave dynasty*

During the period of Delhi Sultanate, i.e. 1206-1526 A.D., architecture can be categorised into two broad categories:

- I. **Imperial Style:** Patronised by the rulers of the Delhi
- II. **Provincial Style:** Patronised by local rulers and fiefs.

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